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Head of Sports,
Disney Star

mer MD of IMG India and a key architect of the IPL, Disney can make a significant difference to Hotstar’s content library. “It can easily rival Netflix and Amazon Prime Video on western content, plus there is a powerful appeal for children. In terms of focus, Disney could well invest hugely in building Hotstar, perhaps de-emphasising some traditional television in the process,” he says.

THE NETWORK, too, has managed to adapt smartly to the changing times. Shailesh Kapoor, Founder and CEO of consulting firm Ormax India, says leadership for the network, for a long time, centred around its flagship channel, Star Plus. “Today, it

has three pillars—Star Plus, cricket and Hotstar. It is a more diversified portfolio not just in terms of revenue but having a strong positioning as well,” he explains. Broad estimates suggest Star Plus makes ₹1,500 crore each year through advertising (rivals Sony Entertainment Television and Zee TV make around ₹1,000 crore each) in a very difficult market.

Kevin Vaz, Head of Network Entertainment Channels, Disney Star, admits the model has changed. “Now, it is about differentiated content that leads to wholesome entertainment for the family. If you think non-fiction and film shows, it won’t work,” he says. To him, understanding the nuance of each market was what a lot of time went into—romance in Marathi and humour in Telugu being examples. “Today, content has to resonate with the preference of the changing viewer.”

With a wider spread, the entity has more firepower. “It derives strength from the three pillars. Just look at sports and 70-80 per cent of cricket rights that matter is with it,” explains Kapoor. There was a time when it did not have the IPL, BCCI or ICC rights. Now, all three rest with the network.

In many ways, the IPL has really been a revelation. In 2017, the last year when Sony had the broadcasting rights, it raked in television advertising revenue of ₹1,300 crore. Digital was still in its infancy and the then Star, the owner of just that part, is estimated to have made ₹100 crore. Jump to 2021, when Star, reveal industry officials, made ₹2,400 crore through television advertising and another ₹600 crore through Hotstar. Of course, none of this includes subscription revenue and the consensus on the street is that the IPL has worked out well for the network. “There were a lot of people who said what we paid was on the

higher side. But we were and are still convinced that cricket is a part of our long-term strategy,” maintains Madhavan.

His team spared no effort in ensuring the IPL made sound business sense. According to Sanjog Gupta, Disney Star’s Head of Sports, viewership had flattened when Star acquired the IPL rights. “The core cricket fan was not really interested in it and to him, it was merely entertainment. We had to reposition it and say this was genuinely competitive cricket with heroes and rivalries,” he says. To him, sports is a great audience unifier and the IPL presented the perfect opportunity. “For instance, we took the regional



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